Purpose

This memo summarizes potential data sources for analyzing the effects of algorithmic pricing bans on rental markets. I evaluated publicly available and proprietary sources based on geographic coverage, time span, rental-market measures, accessibility, and their potential usefulness for studying recently implemented bans. A central challenge is finding data that extend through the post-ban period and match the cities and localities implementing these policies.

Publicly Available Data

Zillow gives two potentially useful datasets. The Zillow Observed Rent Index (ZORI) offers monthly estimates of typical market-rate rents for multifamily properties from January 2015 through August 2026. Its monthly frequency and recent coverage make it pretty useful for examining changes surrounding the implementation of recent algorithmic pricing bans. The Zillow Observed Renter Demand Index (ZORDI) could provide an additional outcome by measuring engagement with rental listings as a proxy for rental demand. The main limitation of both datasets is geography: the downloaded series are measured at the metropolitan level, while many algorithmic pricing bans apply only within individual cities.

The American Community Survey (ACS) provides a useful addition to Zillow. ACS 5-year estimates are available at the city/place level and provide measures of housing affordability and renter characteristics. For example, Table B25070 reports gross rent as a percentage of household income and could be used to construct measures of rent burden. However, the downloaded data currently extend only through 2024, providing no post-treatment information for policies implemented beginning in 2025. The use of five-year pooled estimates also makes ACS less appropriate for detecting short-run policy effects.

Other publicly available sources include the American Housing Survey (AHS) and HUD Fair Market Rents (FMR). AHS provides detailed household- and housing-unit-level information but has less consistent geographic coverage for the individual cities implementing bans. HUD FMR provides a long annual series of standardized gross-rent estimates, including estimates by bedroom size. However, FMR is an administratively constructed rent measure rather than a direct measure of individual market transactions and may not geographically align with city-level policies.

Private and Proprietary Data

A few private sources could potentially provide more detailed measures of rental-market conditions. RealPage is particularly important because its market analytics data focus on multifamily housing and include rents, concessions, occupancy, supply, absorption, lease terms, availability, and other property-level and market-level measures; it is also in the headlines. Apartment List, Cotality, and RentHub also provide rental-market measures at various geographic levels. These sources could deal with some of the geographic or outcome limitations of the publicly available datasets.

The main problem is that some of these datasets require subscriptions, institutional access, paid plans, or contact with the provider, and their full historical coverage isn't always publicly documented. Before pursuing these sources further, it would be useful to figure out if UIC has existing access to any of the proprietary rental-market databases.

Recommendation

Based on the initial inventory, Zillow's multifamily ZORI seems to be the strongest immediately accessible candidate for measuring rent changes. It provides monthly observations, a substantial pre-treatment period, coverage through 2026, and a measure specifically focused on multifamily rentals. ZORDI could provide a secondary outcome measuring rental demand. The primary concern with Zillow is that metropolitan-level observations don't correspond exactly with city-level treatment boundaries.

ACS data could complement Zillow by providing city-level affordability measures and renter characteristics. However, ACS is better suited to establishing pre-treatment conditions or longer-run outcomes than to measuring the immediate effects of recently implemented bans.

Before selecting a final analytical dataset, I think figuring out whether more geographically detailed proprietary multifamily data are available through UIC. If such access is unavailable, a combination of Zillow for recent rental-market outcomes and ACS for city-level affordability and demographic measures appears to be the best starting point.